

Chapter 13

On the Sharing of Ideas and Power of Dialogue



As a leading Chinese think tanker and scholar, I am frequently invited to speak at a wide range of forums, exchanges, and events, mostly on topics related to China's role in the world and what it is planning next. Inevitably, I find that my audiences are woefully uninformed about China's current situation, its intentions, and its potential contribution to the world. What's worse is that most of them have either never been to China or at least haven't visited China for a number of years. When changes are happening at what has been called "China speed," this is a critical failure in Chinese outreach.

The previous chapters of this book have presented a wide range of articles that not only address issues but also show how China has conducted itself on the international stage overtime as well as the positions it takes on a number of issues. They have also demonstrated China's view of the role, achievements, and potential future of globalization in today's world. As waves of protectionism, nationalism, and generally inward-looking mentalities spread throughout countries that had previously been champions of an open, globally linked world, China seems to be one of a select few continuing the push for a model of global governance that promotes mutual benefit, common goals, and development for all countries.

However, while these trends may lead some to sound a death knell for globalization, change does not exist in a vacuum, and the end of one thing is often the beginning of another. The opportunities created by the disruptive policies of the Trump 2.0 era are forcing the world to look at old problems from a new perspective and establish new relationships when old ones sour. Traditional Chinese notions of balance and the cyclical nature of the world provide my Chinese colleagues and me with a unique perspective on current changes and enable us to consider potentially unique alternatives to meet this new and unpredictable world in which we find ourselves.

In this, the penultimate chapter of this book, I would like to share a few of my recent speeches, specifically those given at the United Nations Security Council, Oxford Union, Harvard University, and Princeton University, as well as a piece I wrote on the passing of my good friend and colleague, Joseph Nye, with whom I

spent many hours debating and discussing our similarities and differences, but always with the goal of finding a better way.

The first speech I would like to share is one that I delivered at the United Nations Security Council to address the trend toward unilateralism and bullying in the world today, specifically by the United States. The United Nations was founded with the goal of maintaining international peace and security, developing friendly relations among nations and promoting social progress, better living standards, and human rights. This naturally requires a level of mutual respect, discussion, and ultimately compromise, which are concepts that seem increasingly foreign to the United States under Trump 2.0.

The title I chose for my speech, “The Impact of Unilateralism and Bullying Practices on International Relations,” represents the sentiment of China and much of the developing world, which have the most to lose from a turn away from globalization and multilateralism, which has been most direct in the United States. Both domestically and internationally, President Trump has made unilateral decisions that, because of the size and influence of the United States, affect the world directly and deeply, most directly in trade and economic exchanges. The sudden imposition of tariffs, which in the case of China reached up to 245% at their highest, sent countries into panic mode. This style of fiscal bullying in the name of protecting American workers and the American economy is irresponsible at best and may have long reaching destructive repercussions that the world must deal with in the longer term.

The next speech comes from one of the greatest honors I have received to date, when I became the first Chinese think tank scholar to speak at the Oxford Union. Being invited to speak on China’s behalf and be heard as an equal at the century-old forum is a clear sign that change is possible and the barriers to communication between East and West are coming down. As the title “Democracy in China, Trump’s Planned Tariffs, How the West Misunderstands China, and More” suggests, the speech covers a wide range of topics, which is important considering the lack of understanding that exists with regard to China’s actual situation and its true motivations. In it, I share a great deal of my personal journey, from my studies abroad and my work in building bridges both before and after the founding of the Center for China and Globalization. It has been my life’s mission to open channels of communication and build bridges between civilizations, societies, and individuals in order to explore the best solutions to today’s most pressing issues.

The next speech I would like to share is very personal to me. Harvard University is a name that is known the world over and people often “name drop” to show that they have some sort of connection to this august institution. However, in sharing this speech, I hope to show how the personal impact and inspiration I derived from my time as a fellow at the Kennedy School and my continued relationship with many of the academics and even fellow students there have directed and informed my work as the founder of the Center for China and Globalization as well as one of China’s leading think tank scholars.

Titled “From Academic Insights to Global Governance—On the Path to Breaking Through Sino-US Relations,” this speech draws on the lessons I learned at Harvard and brought back to China to give today’s researchers and students a new perspective

on the most pressing issues facing US-China relations and how we could potentially move beyond the contentious and potentially destructive rivalry that currently exists between our two countries to create a more mutually beneficial future.

The last speech in this chapter was given at Princeton University, at the inaugural commencement of the Princeton China Forum. In preparing for this speech, I was inspired by Princeton's motto, "In the Nation's Service and the Service of Humanity." As many people know, one of China's unofficial mottos is "Serve the People," so Princeton's motto resonated with me in a very unique way. The title I gave to my speech was "In Service of Humanity—On the Greater Mission of Academics and Learning," focusing on the fact that we as academics, whether we are researchers, teachers or students, are ultimately tasked with the betterment of society in service to humanity. The contribution by academia to the world is incredible—from trade that creates prosperity for a greater portion of the world's people, to healthcare that prevents and combats all manner of illness, to security that ensures people live in a peaceful and stable world, to technological breakthroughs that take us into the next stage of human development, the ultimate goal is to betterment of all human beings.

The final two pieces in this chapter are not easy to include in this book. This year, two scholars who made indelible marks on the world in their respective fields, were lost to us. Their passing has left an empty space in both academics and the think tank community that will not be easily filled.

The first of these is a memorial to someone whose vision, passion, and drive inspired me for many years. Professor Joseph S. Nye Jr., who left this world on May 6, 2025, leaves behind an indelible impact on the world, not only in academics, but in government, society, and the popular imagination. Known as the "Father of Soft Power," he viewed the world in a different way and believed that power could be expressed in many ways, not always through political or military means. In our many hours of discussion over the years, which included formal discussion and private correspondence, one of the things that impressed me the most was his belief that our fate is not sealed—that we as individuals or as nations, can pursue a better future, a future that inspires and enriches the world.

The second is in memory of a colleague and an icon in the think tank community. While we came from essentially opposite points of view and regularly took opposing positions on a number of issues, Dr. Edwin J. Feulner of the Heritage Foundation was a treasured friend and valuable asset in the promotion of real exchange and dialogue between the United States and China. Both before and after his time as head of the Heritage Foundation, Dr. Feulner regularly engaged in conversations with me and ensured that the channels of communication remained open and active between our respective institutions. It is his willingness to engage with opponents that helped overcome or even avoid misunderstandings and find common ground upon which more solid foundations could be built. I am confident that both the Heritage Foundation and we at CCG will continue to honor his legacy moving forward despite potential difficulties in US-China relations.

The Impact of Unilateralism and Bullying Practices on International Relations¹

The departure of the United States from its supportive position on globalization is disruptive to the global trade system that benefited it all the while disrupting other smaller economies. The world must come together to build a new sustainable form of globalization that benefits all.

Distinguished Delegates, Ladies and Gentlemen,

Good day. It is an honor to join you all today as we gather to discuss the grave challenges confronting global governance and the international economy. This year marks the 80th anniversary of the founding of the United Nations—a milestone that reminds us of the fundamental norms that underpin modern international relations. The purposes and principles enshrined in the UN Charter, especially the advocacy of multilateralism, have been broadly accepted and upheld by most countries in the world.

Over the decades, despite an evolving global landscape, the United Nations has maintained its central role in coordinating international affairs and, on the whole, the world has remained peaceful and stable, while economic globalization has emerged as a defining trend of our times. Concepts like interdependence among nations and the vision of a shared future have gained wide recognition, while most nations have embraced a goal of mutual benefit and common development.

However, in recent years, there has been a troubling rise in unilateralism and economic coercion. These practices are inflicting profound and far-reaching harm on global economic growth, the implementation of the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), people's livelihoods, and the broader international political and economic order. Unilateral measures—characterized by high tariffs, economic sanctions, technology blockades, and efforts at decoupling—have been especially pronounced in the hegemonic actions of the United States. These actions have not only constricted the foreign trade of developing countries but also disrupted their already fragile economies but also undermined global efforts to alleviate poverty and promote education and health.

For many countries, including those in Europe, these unilateral moves have eroded the trust underpinning multilateral cooperation and intensified policy fragmentation and market uncertainty. More alarmingly, this growing unilateral tendency to act

¹ On April 23, 2025, CCG President Henry Huiyao Wang briefed the UNSC session on “The Impact of Unilateralism and Bullying Practices on International Relations.” Convened by the People's Republic of China and moderated by Fu Cong, China's Permanent Representative to the United Nations. The meeting was broadcast live and remains available on UN WebTV with interpretation in all six UN official languages. Wang was one of two briefers for the meeting, alongside Jeffrey David Sachs, director of the Center for Sustainable Development at Columbia University and president of the UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network. Following the briefers, representatives of some UN member states also spoke.

outside international norms is accelerating the erosion of the global governance architecture centered on the United Nations and the World Trade Organization (WTO), increasing fragmentation and instability in the world order.

In this context, it is all the more crucial to uphold multilateralism and strengthen international cooperation. It is only through multilateral mechanisms that we will be able to effectively address global challenges and foster a fair, balanced, and sustainable international economic order.

As the United States turns away from the path of globalization, the global economy faces tremendous uncertainty. According to the WTO's "Global Trade Outlook and Statistics" report released on April 16, 2025, the volume of global trade in goods is projected to decline by 0.2% in 2025. Should current tensions escalate, the decline could reach 1.5%. On the same day, World Bank President Ajay Banga cautioned that the trade war and tariff policies initiated by President Trump have increased global uncertainty and may further slow global economic growth. Similarly, IMF Managing Director Kristalina Georgieva warned that uncertainty over global trade policies is "off the charts" and would lead to "notable markdowns" in growth estimates. This trend has raised serious concerns about the future trajectory of the global economy.

First, the current trade war is, in essence, a trade war initiated by the US government against the rest of the world. It has disrupted the international order and caused significant harm to the global economy. Overall, the growth of global trade has driven economic expansion and prosperity worldwide, fostering increasingly close ties among national economies. Since the establishment of the WTO 30 years ago, global trade volume has surged from US\$5 trillion in 1994 to US\$33 trillion in 2024—an increase of more than fivefold. A prolonged trade war would severely hinder global economic development and stability.

As the world's largest economy, the United States has long accounted for over 25% of global GDP. The US dollar, serving as the dominant international reserve currency, makes up around 60% of global foreign exchange reserves. These advantages have allowed the United States to reap enormous benefits from economic globalization, making it undeniably one of the greatest beneficiaries of free trade and the current international economic order. However, in recent years, the United States has increasingly downplayed the gains it has made from free trade, portraying the international trade system as unfair. Rather than actively advancing globalization, it has increasingly acted to disrupt it.

Second, the so-called US trade deficit presents only a partial picture. While there is a deficit in the trade of goods, the United States maintains substantial surpluses in services, investment, and talent. In the services sector alone, the United States posts a trade volume of over \$1 trillion with a surplus of \$300 billion.

Moreover, as the world's primary payment currency, the US dollar enables the United States to leverage its deficit position to acquire global resources at scale. The dollar's role as the dominant global settlement currency provides the United States with enormous advantages. These conditions have cemented America's dominance of the global economy and attracted substantial international investment. As a result, US stock markets consistently reach new highs, buoyed by strong global capital inflows.

It is important to note that although the United States does in fact run a deficit in goods, it has also deliberately phased out certain sectors of manufacturing—particularly those that are pollution-intensive or labor-intensive. These industries are often less desirable to American workers, have a greater environmental impact, and typically yield slower investment returns. As a result, their relocation to labor-abundant countries—most of which are developing economies—has been part of a natural process of global economic restructuring.

Against this backdrop, the United States has redirected its focus and resources toward high-tech industries, education, life sciences, the digital economy, and artificial intelligence. These sectors have seen rapid innovation and growth, enabling the United States to maintain a leading position globally. While the United States has retreated from certain areas of traditional manufacturing, this shift does not suggest a loss of overall competitiveness. Rather, in line with the principle of comparative advantage, countries have increasingly specialized in different sectors, highlighting their strengths and complementarities. The United States continues to hold a significant advantage in the global economy, but it cannot expect to be the winner in every field.

Third, the trade war has significantly hindered the normal operations of multinational corporations, which rely on finely tuned global value chains marked by specialization and close coordination. These networks are essential for reducing costs, improving efficiency, and responding quickly to market demands. However, the imposition of high tariffs and heightened policy uncertainty caused by the trade war have not achieved the so-called “reshoring of manufacturing.” Instead, they have severely disrupted global economic arrangements.

The impact on developing countries has been particularly severe. Many of these nations serve as suppliers of raw materials, primary processing hubs, or assembly centers within global value chains. Their economies are highly dependent on export-oriented industries. When trade wars erupt between major economies, global demand weakens, supply chains are disrupted, and investor confidence declines. As a result, these already fragile developing economies are often the first to suffer.

Fourth, history has shown the dangers of protectionism. In the 1930s, under the pretext of “protecting domestic industries,” the United States imposed tariffs of over 50% on nearly 2,000 imported goods. This policy ultimately plunged the United States into the Great Depression and inflicted widespread hardship across the globe. In 2018, the United States imposed additional tariffs on \$250 billion worth of Chinese goods, causing American consumers to pay an extra \$57 billion annually in tariff-related costs.

Today, the United States accounts for only 13% of global merchandise imports, a notable decline from nearly 20% two decades ago. This suggests that the United States alone lacks the leverage to reverse the course of economic globalization. Simon Evenett, a professor at the International Institute for Management Development (IMD) in Switzerland, found that if America’s trading partners maintain their current export growth rates to other markets, 70 of them could fully make up their lost sales to the United States within one year, and 115 partners could do so within five years.

Fifth, economic globalization is an unstoppable trend. In the face of rising protectionism, the momentum to safeguard and advance globalization is gathering strength. China has implemented zero-tariff policies for more than 40 least developed countries, aiming to better support the development of the broader Global South. The deepening of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), the advancement of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), and the expansion of the BRICS bloc all demonstrate that globalization continues to be embraced by the vast majority of the international community.

Today, the overwhelming aspiration of most nations is not to reject or abandon globalization, but to build a more inclusive and equitable form of globalization that benefits all. At a time when the world is facing not one but several unprecedented crises, we must strengthen cooperation and work together to safeguard global peace and development.

Democracy in China, Trump's Planned Tariffs, How the West Misunderstands China, and More²

The key to a future that is secure, prosperous, and peaceful is cooperation. China's return to the world stage, riding the wave of globalization, as well as recent advances in green technology, has put it in a unique place to have a positive impact on guiding the next step of global development.

Late last year, as I prepared for a speech at the Oxford Union, I was reminded of Charles Dickens' famous line, "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times," in *A Tale of Two Cities*. Today, his words resonate once again as we face a world defined by dualities.

On the one hand, we are living in an era of unprecedented advancements. The global economy has expanded many times, technological innovations are reshaping every facet of our lives, and cross-cultural exchanges have created a tightly linked "global village."

On the other hand, we are also threatened by immense global challenges. The ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and the conflict between Israel and Palestine have destabilized entire regions and raised fears of a Third World War. Meanwhile, climate change is having unprecedented catastrophic consequences, from devastating wildfires to rising sea levels. Global pandemics, like COVID-19, have also exposed vulnerabilities in our public health systems.

Additionally, the rapid advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) poses ethical and economic dilemmas, while developing countries face mounting debt issues.

At this critical moment and crossroads, we need to work together for a better future, and key collaboration between major global powers like China, the United States, and Europe with the Global South is both urgent and essential.

A Personal Microcosm

My personal journey is intimately intertwined with globalization and the process by which the world reached this point in its history and also explains why I'm so keen on globalization and building bridges. Therefore, I'd like to give a little background on myself.

I was born in Chengdu, the bustling capital of Sichuan Province, home to China's famous pandas and known for its rich culture and delicious Sichuan cuisine. But for

² On November 27, 2024, Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder & President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), made history as the first Chinese think tank scholar to address the Oxford Union, the world's prestigious debating society, with an unparalleled reputation for bringing international guests and speakers to Oxford. Since 1823, the Union has been promoting debate and discussion not just in Oxford University but across the globe. This piece is adapted from his speech in the Oxford Union in April 2025.

the last 45 years, I have witnessed firsthand China's development through its reform and opening-up process.

At the age of 17, like many young people of my generation, I was sent to a rural village as part of the "down to the countryside" movement. The years I spent living in a simple thatched hut and working alongside farmers were incredibly challenging but deeply formative. There was no electricity or running water, only wells we had to pump for drinking water; there wasn't even enough food. It was so cold in the wintertime that I had to drink hot water with chilies to keep myself warm. Life was harsher than I could have imagined during the Cultural Revolution and it was difficult to keep your body and soul together. There was only work—from dusk till dawn. My daily income was just 20 Chinese "cents," which was equivalent to about three US cents at the time. From this, you can see how far China has progressed. It was a very difficult time for me, and one of my most treasured possessions was a small radio that connected me to the outside world, offering glimpses of hope and knowledge amidst the hardship.

Then, in the winter of 1977, the village loudspeaker broadcast a message that "the government will reinstate the university entrance exam," which had been suspended for a decade during the Cultural Revolution. The moment I heard the news, I jumped at the opportunity and started preparing by using my radio to study English with "Follow Me." This transformation brought by Deng Xiaoping's reform and opening-up policy was the beginning of my journey with globalization; it not only opened China to the world, but also completely changed my future.

The first round of entrance exams saw six million candidates, which had been unable to participate in the exams during the ten years of Cultural Revolution, competing for just 250,000 spots—a daunting 1:25 acceptance rate. I was fortunate to get accepted, and I received my bachelor's degree in English and American literature, which became the foundation for my later involvement in international affairs and opened a door to a world of opportunities.

After my first degree, I served in the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Trade and Economic Cooperation in Beijing in the early 1980s and later was able to pursue an MBA in Canada, becoming one of the first MBA students from China to study in Canada. Then, I went on to obtain my PhD at the University of Western Ontario and the University of Manchester, here in the United Kingdom. I also became a Senior Fellow at Harvard Kennedy School and a Visiting Fellow at the Brookings Institution. Seeing the world with my own eyes was different from my previous experience in China. These learning experiences have helped me look at the world more objectively. I regard myself as an example of one of the many that have benefitted from China's reform and opening-up.

After my studies in Canada, I worked for one of the largest multinational companies in Canada, SNC-Lavalin. Later, I went through several rounds of interviews and was appointed Chief Trade Representative for the Quebec Government Office for Hong Kong and Greater China. Those years were also a period of major transformation for China, which the world was watching closely. After coming back to China as a "returnee entrepreneur," I started a company that I ran for many years. At that time, one of the most important things was how to promote the entrepreneurial

spirit in China. After years in the corporate sector, I finally went back to academic life and became an adjunct professor at Guanghua School of Management in Peking University, where I taught international management.

When I was young, my parents told me constantly, “You must read 10,000 books and travel 10,000 miles,” which has profoundly influenced my outlook on the world. Education was in my blood, starting with my great-grandfather, who was a dean at Yuelu Academy in Hunan Province, which has a history of more than a thousand years. My parents worked as engineers on China’s vast railway network and often took me on their travels to many places. Those experiences cultivated my fascination with the world beyond China, including Africa, thanks to my father’s travels to Tanzania and Zambia to help work on TAZARA, China’s railway project in Africa in the 1970s. This had an enormous influence on me.

Building a New Bridge

After my entrepreneurial and academic careers, I began thinking about how I could combine my experiences in government, business, and academia. Creating a uniquely Chinese global think tank was one of the first things that came to my mind.

I co-founded the Center for China & Globalization (CCG) with Dr. Mabel Miao in 2008, just as China was holding the Summer Olympics Games. The theme of the Games that year was “One World, One Dream,” which perfectly symbolized the spirit of globalization. This inspired me to found a non-governmental think tank in China that focused on globalization. But at that time, a lot of people were suspicious, asking, “Why would you put ‘globalization’ in your think tank’s name? Globalization means Westernization and Americanization.” But we pushed ahead, holding forums and publishing a lot of books. We established CCG with the goal of building bridges and fostering connections between China and the outside world. Guided by our newly coined motto, “Global Vision for China, Chinese Wisdom for the World,” we have continually worked to serve as a global connector, bridge builder, and cross-cultural adapter that promotes mutual understanding and collaboration between China and the world.

CCG has become a phenomenon and one of the most productive think tanks in China. I’m very pleased to say that CCG has seen impressive progress over the last 17 years, conducting in-depth research on key aspects of China’s experiences in globalization, while also providing suggestions to policymakers both in China and abroad. As a non-governmental organization, CCG is the only think tank in China that has been granted special consultative status by the United Nations. For many years in a row, CCG has been ranked among the world’s top 100 think tanks and the top 50 best independent think tanks in the world by the Global Go To Think Tank Index published by the University of Pennsylvania Think Tank and Civil Society Program.

CCG played an especially important role during the pandemic as the first Chinese think tank to reach out to the world. Before restrictions had been fully lifted, we visited

six countries over the period of a month and engaged with different global communities and government officials, bridging the gap between China and the outside world. Since the pandemic broke out, I also personally hosted a series called “CCG Global Dialogues” with nearly 100 prominent global thought leaders, including Jim O’Neill, Martin Wolf, Thomas Friedman, Graham Allison, Lawrence Summers, Joseph Nye, Ray Dalio, Arancha González, Pascal Lamy, Niall Ferguson and many more. These videos can still be found on our YouTube channel and official website. In the United Kingdom, I talked with Martin Wolf for two hours and the videos of our dialogue have been viewed around two million times. When I spoke with Larry Summers, he said, “Look, Henry, China lifted 800 million people out of poverty, which is an achievement comparable to the Industrial Revolution in Great Britain.” I also talked to Pascal Lamy, who was the former Director-General of the WTO. He said, “Trade is so vital. Globalization will not stop.”

We’ve published more than 100 books in English and Chinese on global issues, as well as multiple research reports, which have reached many readers at home and abroad. Our three English newsletters—Pekingnology, The East is Read, and CCG Update—reach 30,000 subscribers from government offices, multinational news agencies and think tanks worldwide. It’s of great significance to keep the dialogue going and the windows of communication open between China and the world.

Over the course of 17 years, CCG has provided support to government policy-makers on domestic and global issues with proposals and recommendations, many of which have been acted on by different levels of government. CCG has also hosted high-profile forums that have become known for their international impact, welcoming thousands of participants from China and abroad. CCG also frequently partners with prestigious global forums, such as the Munich Security Conference, the Paris Peace Forum, the Athens Democracy Forum, the Doha Forum, the Bled Strategic Forum and the Boao Forum to promote more balanced and constructive dialogues.

CCG also hosted many ministerial-level guests from different countries and this year, we have been proud to host regular international ambassador roundtable luncheons in Beijing. These events have received positive feedback and generated meaningful dialogue with over 50 foreign ambassadors based in Beijing, making CCG a hub for international exchanges between China and the world.

Looking to the future, I would like to present three concrete proposals in my role as a think tank scholar and witness to China’s unique experiences.

Firstly, I propose a UN Peace Summit to end the wars in Ukraine and the Middle East.

President Trump has shown his resolve to make a deal and China is also ready to help with this process with a proposal of a 12-point peace plan for Ukraine. But far from waiting for the United States, China, and Brazil have also jointly proposed a 6-point peace plan for Ukraine, in addition to forming a “Friends of Peace” initiative for Ukraine along with Brazil and South Africa.

China’s role as a mediator is becoming increasingly significant. Its economic influence and diplomatic ties allow it to foster dialogue where other nations might struggle. For example, China is the largest trading partner of both Russia and Ukraine.

This dual connection provides China with unmatched economic leverage, enabling it to act as a neutral intermediary. China could participate in post-war reconstruction efforts for both Ukraine as well as Palestine.

China also has one of the biggest peacekeeping forces among the five permanent members of the UN Security Council. China's recent diplomatic successes, such as brokering the restoration of ties between Iran and Saudi Arabia, have demonstrated its capability. Leveraging its position as the largest oil importer of both nations, China facilitated a groundbreaking reconciliation. China recently gathered 14 Palestinian factions in Beijing, contributing to the signing of the Beijing Declaration on Ending Division and Strengthening Palestinian National Unity. China could also inspire North Korea to join China-Japan-South Korea trilateral talks and even encourage its participation in regional frameworks like RCEP and CPTPP.

I regard protecting peace as the most important issue in our time and China, the United States, the EU, the United Kingdom, and Global South have to work together to prevent a third World War. As early as March 2022, I called for a Seven Parties Talks model including P5 countries plus the EU and Ukraine, to work toward a UN Peace Summit.

My second proposal is to confront our shared challenge—climate change.

A major flood hit Spain a few weeks ago, resulting in serious fatalities, and last year was the hottest year on record. We are currently witnessing the dire consequences of climate change and need to truly work together based on the guidelines of the Paris Agreement.

A decade ago, Beijing was enveloped in a dense shroud of smog, painting a grim tableau reminiscent of the soot-laden streets of nineteenth-century London described by Charles Dickens in *Oliver Twist*. The air was thick with pollutants, obscuring skyscrapers and casting a gray pall over daily life. At that time, the US embassy installed a pollution monitoring device on its roof and began publishing daily PM2.5 air quality data, highlighting the dire urgency of confronting the pollution crisis—especially since nearly half of it stemmed from the emissions of vehicles that clogged the city's traffic arteries. This alarming situation sparked an awakening among the Chinese public about the vital importance of environmental protection.

Today, 60% of the pollution in Beijing is caused by car emissions, which is why China started to develop EV cars and is currently the world's largest producer. China has achieved significant advancements in renewable energy, now producing 90% of the world's solar panels. China is leading the green power transition, but this transition requires all countries to work together. Some countries accuse China of overcapacity and flooding global markets in new energy, but according to the International Energy Agency, global demand for new photovoltaic installations will reach 820 gigawatts, about four times that of 2022, if the goal set by the Paris Agreement is met. This means that the world must invest \$4.5 trillion per year in clean energy, far behind the total amount spent in 2023 on global clean energy, which was only \$1.8 trillion. Far from oversupply, we need to set aside our differences and produce more green energy solutions.

Many years ago, US President Ronald Reagan asked Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev, "If aliens were to attack the United States, would the Soviet Union come

to our aid?" Gorbachev replied, "Yes." Then Gorbachev posed the same question: "If aliens attacked the Soviet Union, would the United States come to our aid?" Reagan also answered, "Yes." Today, the "alien" we all face is climate change—a threat to all of humanity that demands our collective effort and cooperation to overcome. There's no reason for us to separate when facing these common challenges. Climate change is our biggest threat and a common enemy. I propose an annual G10 Summit of the 10 largest carbon producers to concentrate on coming up with global solutions in fighting climate change.

The last proposal is about artificial intelligence, which is a double-edged sword that requires true global governance.

Artificial intelligence is a concept and an issue that can't be avoided. It now permeates many facets of everyday life. Two years ago, the inaugural Global AI Summit in London underscored the urgency of addressing artificial intelligence as both an opportunity and a challenge, with China actively contributing to the discussions. As the two biggest AI developers, if the United States and China were to go separate routes, it would be a huge challenge.

Europe, however, has a greater willingness to work with China on AI. In June 2024, I cohosted a seminar with the German Ambassador Patricia Flor and French Ambassador Bertrand Lortholary to highlight the ongoing urgency surrounding AI governance and regulation. I am confident that European countries can make a huge contribution to mitigating the concerns around AI by setting new regulations and serving as a mediator between China and the United States on AI issues.

As we navigate an era of both great promise and immense challenges, it is clear that global cooperation is no longer optional—it is essential. Regardless of whether we are addressing geopolitical conflicts, combating climate change, or shaping the digital economy, the shared responsibility of major powers—China, the United States, and Europe—will define the future of our interconnected world. The COVID-19 pandemic showed us how vulnerable human beings can be without mutual support. The world has so many burning issues going on that need major powers to work together.

History has shown us that when nations work together, they can overcome even the most daunting obstacles. By fostering dialogue, promoting mutual understanding, and leveraging our collective strengths, we can build a more peaceful, sustainable, and prosperous global community. Let us move forward with a shared vision and a commitment to collaboration, ensuring that the challenges of today become the opportunities of tomorrow. Together, I am confident that we can safeguard global peace and stability for generations to come.

From Academic Insights to Global Governance—On the Path to Breaking Through Sino-US Relations³

A few lessons drawn from the “Spirit of Harvard” in moving beyond trade protectionism, and towards mutual understanding through people-to-people exchanges, as well as uncovering new avenues for cooperation.

Dear professors, students, and friends,

Returning to Harvard Kennedy School, walking among the familiar red-brick buildings, the shimmering waters of the Charles River and Harvard Square lights seem to weave a tunnel through time. Almost 40 years ago, I first arrived here, launching my in-depth exploration of Sino-US relations and Globalization studies in this beautiful campus that has witnessed countless intellectual debates and exchanges. This experience is like a prism, reflecting both the wisdom of academia and the complex spectrum of great-power relations.

My Journey with Harvard: A Dialogue Across Minds

I first came to Harvard in 1986, invited by my brother Wang Huijin, who was one of the six founding members of Chinese Economists Society (CES). Qian Yingyi was the president of CES at Harvard then and many Chinese students and scholars had come to Harvard for the annual CES Conference. This first experience created an enduring bond with Harvard that has lasted until the present day.

Later, my incredible academic experience as a senior fellow at Harvard Kennedy School in 2011 inspired me to write a book titled *The Path of Public Management Elites at Harvard*, becoming the first Chinese author to offer a firsthand account of experiences at the Kennedy School.

Over time, my connection with Harvard deepened significantly. I benefited tremendously from my interactions with many of its renowned professors, including Larry Summers, Joseph Nye, Graham Allison, William Kirby, and Tony Sachs and have had many interesting discussions with them over the years. Professor Nye’s influential works, like *Soft Power and Great Power Competition*, have been included in the “China and Globalization” series published by my own think tank, the Center for China and Globalization. His latest autobiography, *A Life in the American Century*, is also currently being translated and will also be published in China by CCG.

Graham Allison, who is my great friend, is a legendary figure and often regarded as the “next Kissinger” in US-China relations. I had the privilege of engaging in many intense dialogues with Professor Allison, which ultimately led to one of our

³ On April 26, 2025, Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder and President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG) delivered a speech and engaged in panel discussion at China Conference, a student-run conference at Harvard Kennedy School. This is adapted from his speech.

most recent publications *Escaping Thucydides's Trap* in both English and Chinese, which highlights the vital pathways of how to avoid the pitfalls of the Thucydides's Trap and effectively manage China-US relations.

Sino-US Economic and Trade Relations: Seeing Through Data to Break Cognitive Misconceptions in Sino-US Economic and Trade Relations

• The Destructiveness of Trade Wars

The current trade war is essentially a unilateral challenge by the US government against not only China but also the world, disrupting the international order and severely impacting the global economy. Since the founding of the WTO 30 years ago, global trade has grown from \$5 trillion in 1994 to \$33 trillion in 2024—but trade wars threaten this progress. As the world's largest economy (accounting for over 25% of global GDP, with the dollar comprising 60% of global foreign exchange reserves), the United States has been the biggest beneficiary of free trade, yet it undermines globalization under the pretext of “unfair trade.”

• The One-Sidedness of Trade Deficits

While recognizing the existence of the US goods trade deficit, we must also point out the significant advantage the United States has in services, in which it showed a \$300 billion surplus in 2024 with a total service trade volume of \$1 trillion. Additionally, advantages like the dollar's seigniorage and overseas investment returns highlight America's dominance. American society has also benefited tremendously from global talent. In terms of numbers, over 60% of Nobel laureates work in the United States, 30% of American AI professionals are from China, and Chinese students make up 36% of all international PhD graduates in STEM fields in the United States. Many Chinese students also choose to stay in the United States to work, contributing greatly to its talent base and overall economy. In many ways, the transition of the United States from polluting, labor-intensive industries to high-tech sectors reflects comparative advantage, not “trade failure.”

• Shocks to Global Industrial Chains

Trade wars disrupt global supply chains that rely on complex division of labor. High tariffs and policy uncertainty have had no foreseeable impact on “manufacturing reshoring,” while at the same time damaging developing nations—Southeast Asian export-oriented manufacturing has seen plummeting orders, and African raw material exporters face fiscal pressures. Historical lessons are stark: in 1930, the United States passed the Smoot-Hawley Tariff Act, leading to a 60% contraction in global trade. In 2018, tariffs imposed on Chinese goods caused American consumers to pay an additional \$57 billion annually. Today, the share of imported goods in the US market

has fallen from 20% two decades ago to 13%, demonstrating the difficulty of reversing the trend of globalization.

- **The Resilience of Globalization**

In the face of rising protectionism, the forces supporting globalization are gathering momentum. China has implemented zero-tariff policies for over 40 of the world's least developed countries. Meanwhile, the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), the African Continental Free Trade Area, and the expansion of the BRICS group all indicate that economic globalization remains a shared aspiration among many nations around the world.

Breaking Through: Rebuilding Global Consensus Through People-to-People Exchanges

1. Educational Exchanges: Cultivating Future Understanders and Collaborators

Educational exchange lies at the heart of China-US people-to-people interactions. Every year, large numbers of Chinese and American students study abroad, becoming ambassadors of their respective cultures and fostering communication. Research by CCG shows that over 80% of Chinese students who studied in the United States gained a deeper understanding of American society and many actively promote people-to-people exchanges upon returning home. Likewise, American students who come to China gain a more objective view of the country by experiencing its culture and technological development firsthand. Educational exchanges thus nurture future talent with cross-cultural competencies, reduce misunderstandings caused by cultural differences, and foster cooperation across various fields. China has also been proactive in this area with President Xi inviting 50,000 American students to visit China over a five-year period, resulting in 16,000 American students visiting China in 2024 alone.ⁱⁿ

2. Track II Diplomacy: Strengthening the Social Foundations of China-US Relations

Civil society, represented by think tanks like CCG and many other organizations, have built multi-layered platforms for dialogue by organizing business forums, youth dialogues, and other exchange activities. With its flexibility and broad reach, people-to-people diplomacy penetrates various levels of society, enhancing mutual trust and willingness to cooperate, becoming an increasingly important supplement to official diplomacy.

3. Promoting Peaceful Cooperation on Global Issues

In the context of the Russia-Ukraine war, there is significant potential for China and the United States to cooperate more extensively in promoting peace. President

Trump has expressed reluctance to deploy US troops and called on Europe and other countries to contribute troops if necessary. However, the participation of non-European forces remains uncertain. One viable solution may be the deployment of a UN peacekeeping force composed of personnel from Global South countries should negotiations progress to this level. It is not inconceivable that China could contribute to post-war peacekeeping efforts, provided it receives authorization from the United Nations Security Council and gains unanimous consent from the relevant nations.

4. Boosting Investment Flows

President Donald Trump has verbally and publicly welcomed Chinese companies to invest in the United States, recognizing how this could revitalize its industrial base. This push for re-industrialization aligns with the commercial interests of Chinese companies: the pursuit of growth opportunities and the desire to access a critical consumer base closer to their destination market.

However, beyond statements by the President, it is essential for both the US Congress and the broader government to send positive signals that demonstrate a genuine openness to Chinese investment.

Conclusion: Let the Spirit of Harvard Illuminate a New Era of Globalization

The Harvard experience taught me to analyze problems with data and logic. It also inspired me, through its emphasis on social responsibility and global vision, to devote myself to the research of China-US relations and globalization. The future of China-US relations requires rational decision-making by governments as well as the continued efforts of civil society. We should work to overcome trade protectionism, enhance mutual understanding through people-to-people exchanges, and explore new possibilities for cooperation.

Standing by the Charles River, I recall a sentence I read before, “Politics is ephemeral, scholarship is eternal, and talent is the carrier of civilization.” While Trump’s trade war could potentially be a “coming of age” in great-power relations, it is the academic spirit of institutions like Harvard, the cross-cultural bridges created by international students, and constructive dialogues conducted by think tanks that will ultimately prove that true great power lies in mutual learning between civilizations and true globalization lies in forging consensus amid differences.

In Service of Humanity—On the Greater Mission of Academics and Learning⁴

Dialogue and exchange are central to improving relations between China and the US. From think tank dialogue to academic exchanges, the ultimate product of these discussions is a vital service—both to one’s own nation, and to humanity as a whole.

Distinguished guests, cherished students, and friends,

It is a profound honor to serve as a keynote speaker for the 1st Princeton China Forum. Stepping onto this campus—where Gothic spires guard centuries of inquiry and dogwoods are just beginning to bloom—I feel both humbled and invigorated. Princeton’s motto, “In the Nation’s Service and the Service of Humanity,” captures the aspiration that first propelled me across the Pacific decades ago: the conviction that knowledge is not an ornament for the fortunate few but a lever for the many. To address a university that has nurtured presidents, Nobel laureates, and public servants of every calling is, for me, a homecoming of the spirit.

I first set foot in North America with two suitcases, a dictionary, and more curiosity than cash. After several formative years at China’s Ministry of Foreign Trade, I became eager to understand how the West unlocks human potential. Professors lengthened library hours so a newcomer could finish assignments; host families widened their dinner tables so a stranger could taste Thanksgiving. Those early kindnesses convinced me that trust—an old-fashioned word—can travel faster than any cargo ship, and that when openness meets diligence, national destinies shift.

Years later, I founded the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), now ranked as the top non-governmental think tank in Beijing. CCG has become an unofficial port of call for diplomats seeking ground truth, for professors brainstorming joint studies, for journalists hunting nuance beneath headlines, and for students—American, European, and African—searching for China’s place in their own future. We host dozens of dialogues each year, drawing participants from leading policy centers and universities across North America. It is in those exchanges—where tariffs and technology fears are probed with data rather than slogans—that I learn daily how engagement tempers ambition with realism and realism with empathy.

Collaboration is not a slogan at CCG; it is the workflow. We sustain a deliberately porous workflow: visiting scholars collaborate on fresh policy ideas, graduate students chase down the data that will anchor tomorrow’s theses, and retired trade negotiators still swap war stories in the cafeteria queue. Skeptics arrive with folded arms and leave at least better informed. That iterative enlightenment is how rival powers edge away from collision and toward coexistence.

Universities remain the first stringers in this bridge across the Pacific. Even in seasons of frost, Princeton climatologists co-author with Beijing data scientists; engineers at top schools on both coasts refine battery chemistry with partners in Shenzhen and Suzhou. Science respects no passport queue, and peer review is an

⁴ On Saturday April 19, 2025, Henry Huiyao Wang, Founder & President of the Center for China and Globalization (CCG), delivered a keynote speech at the first Princeton China Forum.

under-appreciated instrument of global security. It is fitting, then, that China now welcomes 50,000 American students over five years—an invitation extended by President Xi Jinping in San Francisco at the end of 2023 and already embraced by nearly 16,000 young Americans in the past year. They are tasting delicacies in Chengdu, my hometown, probing AI ethics in Beijing, and discovering that the China of documentaries and headlines is never quite the China of daily life. If my generation built bridges armed only with paper dictionaries, imagine what theirs will do with AI powered translators at their fingertips.

Exchange, of course, must travel in both directions. Last year, the United States hosted nearly 290,000 Chinese students, injecting into local economies and sustaining a significant number of American jobs. Some will stay, founding start-ups from CRISPR labs in Boston to cloud computing firms in Seattle; many will return home, becoming bilingual ambassadors for American ingenuity in China's vast marketplace. Either way, every dorm room friendship narrows the margin for miscalculation across the Pacific.

Now, let us also speak plainly about trade, for trade still pays tuition and lab fees. Chinese exports shave percentage points off US consumer price inflation each year, cushioning American family budgets at the checkout counter. When tariffs rise, that quiet subsidy disappears; a recent Boston Fed analysis warns that proposed increases could add up to two full points to core inflation if mark ups stick. Affordable toys for children, laptops for college freshmen, spare parts for Midwestern auto shops—all become a little dearer, and the invisible tax falls heaviest on working families.

Conversely, collaboration in advanced manufacturing promises shared prosperity. President Donald Trump has voiced openness to Chinese automakers building plants in America. If clear, predictable rules follow—rules that respect US labor standards and national security concerns—Chinese capital can revive industrial corridors from Michigan to Mississippi, accelerate the rollout of affordable electric vehicles, and create middle-class jobs American voters crave. Competition, then, enlarges the pie before slicing begins.

The digital economy offers an even greater upside. American cloud providers can host Chinese start-ups eyeing global markets, while Chinese e-commerce platforms rely on North American logistics firms to reach last-mile customers in the Midwest. When both sides align technical standards on data protection—a topic CCG has explored with its North American partners—small businesses benefit first: Ohio farmers selling soy snacks online, Sichuan artisans shipping tea sets to Phoenix.

Healthcare, too, rewards cooperation. During the pandemic, US and Chinese scientists jointly sequenced viral genomes; today they refine mRNA platforms for cancer immunotherapy. Shared clinical trials accelerate breakthroughs for patients in Baltimore and Beijing alike. In an aging world, time is our scarcest resource, and collaboration, not rivalry, buys us more of it.

Beneath these sector specific gains lies a sturdier foundation: supply chain resilience. Dialogues with industry leaders show that diversified—not duplicated—routes are the surest insurance against global shocks. Ports on the US coasts benefit from foreign upgrades in handling equipment and software, while ports along China's littoral apply best practices from cold chain logistics and safety protocols developed

abroad. Every incremental improvement lowers the odds that an earthquake in one hemisphere will empty store shelves in the other. Collaboration, again, is not charity; it is enlightened self-interest.

Track II and Track 1.5 diplomacy provide the scaffolding for such progress. At CCG, we convene international business delegations gauging consumer trends, investors seeking sustainable industry partnerships, and educators exploring new models of workforce training. We are determined to make well-tested ideas circulate long before formal positions crystallize into press releases.

To younger generations looking to expand their horizons and take dialogue to the next level, I suggest spending a semester in Beijing, an internship in Hangzhou, or a summer mapping green supply chains along the Yangtze River. Your skills—and your friendships—will outlive any single election cycle. To faculty, craft syllabi that share data while guarding legitimate security concerns; let peer review, not politics, judge science. And to policymakers across Washington and Beijing, remember: the next breakthrough in energy abundance or Alzheimer's therapy may require visas stamped in both directions.

When I first left China, bilateral trade hovered near US\$5 billion; today it is more than one hundred times larger. Numbers that large command their own gravity, pulling suppliers, consumers, and researchers toward collaboration—so long as we keep communications open. Having benefited from North America's openness and China's reform era, I stand convinced that bridges built of curiosity and respect can outlast any storm of suspicion.

Princeton's charge is to serve the nation and, more ambitiously, humanity. Let us—scholars and students, entrepreneurs and officials—strengthen the bridges we have inherited and construct new spans, so future generations inherit affordable goods, resilient industries, and the habit of talking before acting. In doing so, we honor not only our two nations but the common welfare of humankind.

The Legacy of Joseph Nye and His Wisdom for Sino-US Relations⁵

The passing of Joseph Nye is an incalculable loss for the world. His belief in “power with others” gave the world hope that the nations of the future could shape the world together. Let us take a moment to remember his legacy and use it to create a brighter future.

In May, the world lost one of its most thoughtful and influential voices in international affairs: Professor Joseph S. Nye Jr. At 88, he left behind a legacy as a teacher, theorist, and bridge builder between nations. I am deeply saddened by his passing. I was privileged to have known him personally, and as I reflect on our interactions over the years, I am reminded of his immense generosity of spirit, intellectual clarity, and unwavering commitment to peace through understanding.

Joseph Nye will forever be remembered as the architect of the concept of “soft power,” a term that has since become foundational to how we think about global influence. As he often remarked, “One has to imagine not just power over other countries, but power with other countries. These issues, the transnational issues, cannot be solved by exerting power.” His finding that attraction and persuasion often serve countries better than force and coercion shaped the modern field of international relations and served as a guiding light for those dedicated to building bridges between East and West.

I first met Professor Nye in 2010, when I was a senior fellow at Harvard’s Kennedy School of Government. Even then, well into his seventies, he radiated energy and intellectual vitality. He was generous with his time, engaging with young scholars and international visitors alike. We connected immediately and shared meaningful conversations and dialogues over the years. His wisdom stood out not because he was forceful in argument, but because he listened and understood. In a time when diplomacy often falls prey to ideology or arrogance, Nye maintained a conscientious and ethical manner and stood unwavering in his rejection of a fatalistic destiny of inevitable conflict.

Over the years, he remained in regular contact and strongly supported the Center for China and Globalization (CCG). I had a number of dialogues with him. His presence in our programs was always thoughtful, never perfunctory. In April 2021, during the height of the COVID-19 pandemic, he joined me for a virtual CCG Global Dialogue on “Power Shifts in the 21st Century.” For over an hour, we discussed the future of US-China relations. He was sharp, hopeful, and always focused on solutions.

⁵ This essay was written on May 8, 2025 in remembrance of Joseph S. Nye Jr., one of the most influential figures in international relations and a man who shaped decades of American foreign policy and introduced the world to the enduring concept of “soft power,” after learning of his death on May 6th in Cambridge, Massachusetts at the age of 88. A former dean of Harvard’s Kennedy School and senior official in the US government, Nye’s passing marks a profound loss for scholars, diplomats, and policymakers across the globe. As a final tribute, CCG will soon publish the Chinese edition of *A Life in the American Century*, a memoir Nye had previously authorized CCG for publication in mainland China, bringing his legacy to a new generation of readers.

As Nye discussed with me in a 2021 dialogue, US-China ties can be characterized in twenty-year cycles starting in 1950 with war over the Korean Peninsula, to strategic alliance following Nixon's visit to Beijing in the 1970s, through the 90s we saw China integrate, joining the WTO and the US-led economic order. Now in 2025, we stand at the midpoint of the latest 20-year cycle that began with Donald Trump's 2015 presidential candidacy. Properly managed, this present downturn need not be permanent; in Nye's eyes, diplomacy's arc could always bend back toward mutual benefit.

It was in that spirit that he joined us again in 2023 for the launch of his book that I edited for him, *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition: Shifting Sands in the Balance of Power Between the United States and China*, as part of the China and Globalization series I co-edited with Dr. Mabel Lu Miao. Co-published by CCG, Springer in English, and CITIC Press in Chinese, he participated virtually in the book's launch, but his voice was firm and his message urgent. He stressed the need for "guardrails" in US-China ties—not to restrict contact, but to prevent crises. He was particularly concerned about the dangers of decoupling in areas where our interdependence is not only strategic but existential: pandemics, climate change, technological standards, and the global commons.

His warnings were rooted in a deep understanding of theory and history. Nye rejected Cold War analogies, insisting that the US-China relationship was categorically different from that between the United States and the Soviet Union. As he said at CCG's 8th China Global Think Tank Innovation Conference, "We confuse ourselves when we use that terminology." The sheer scale of economic integration, educational exchange, and social interconnectedness between our countries requires a new framework—one where both nations must develop the capacity to work with, not just against, each other.

Even as his health began to wane, his thinking remained sharp and his drive undiminished. He continued to challenge lazy thinking and resisted populist currents. In 2024, he invited me and Dr. Mabel Lu Miao to the Aspen Security Forum, where we met in person for the last time. It was there I had the pleasure of meeting his wife, Molly, who sadly passed away five months before him, in December. At Aspen, he stood firm and made clear his opposition to decoupling between China and the United States. It was also there that we discussed his memoir, *A Life in the American Century*, and he entrusted us with bringing it to a Chinese audience. It was an honor to accept that task. The book is now soon to be published by CCG in partnership with China Science and Technology Press, though he sadly did not live to see it come to fruition. The loss was a blow, and coupled with concerns over his health, gradually drew him away from public engagement. Even in his final months, he remained productive—writing and publishing thoughtful and piercing commentary.

His sudden passing this May came as a deeply unexpected shock. And now as the world could benefit most from his calls for cooperation and understanding—and rejection of reckless decoupling—amidst the turbulent times of the Second Trump Administration and a global order increasingly in upheaval he has departed for the final time. More than anything, I will miss his presence—his clarity, his fairness, and his willingness to engage with China not as an adversary to be defeated, but as a

partner in shaping the future and no decoupling between our two countries. In every exchange, he responded personally. He never stood on ceremony. His humility made his intellect all the more compelling.

He believed that power was not just about coercion or even strategy, but about inspiration. That is why he remained a powerful voice in both academic and policy circles long after retirement. He never stopped trying to improve the world.

For those of us committed to stabilizing and strengthening US-China relations, his life remains a beacon. As I grieve his passing, I also renew my commitment to the work we shared: building understanding, resisting confrontation, and believing—as he did—that our destinies are not a terminal spiral to conflict written in stone. The legacy and legend of Joseph Nye and his wisdom will continue to inspire all of us for Sino-US relations.

Commemorating Edwin J. Feulner—A History of CCG-Heritage Foundation Exchanges⁶

Nearly all great breakthroughs in history have been made by people who come from different points of view. Dr. Edwin J. Feulner, while representative of the conservative American perspective, placed great value on his interactions with China and especially those between CCG and the Heritage Foundation.

Dr. Edwin J. Feulner, founder and long-time president of the Heritage Foundation, passed away at age 83 on July 18, 2025.

The Center for China and Globalization (CCG) had rich interactions with Dr. Feulner and the Heritage Foundation, among other leading US think tanks, over the past fifteen years. In memory of Feulner, we revisit some of the exchanges between CCG and Dr. Feulner's Heritage Foundation. These encounters are a symbol of a spirit of openness and dialogue in Sino-US relations, despite ideological divides. Feulner believed in the value of face-to-face engagement, and his efforts helped bridge understanding between Chinese scholars and their conservative leaning American counterparts. By revisiting these moments, we honor Feulner's memory and reaffirm the importance of keeping dialogue open between China and even the most staunchly conservative US institutions.

Dr. Feulner's warm relationship with CCG began in earnest in 2008, after CCG emerged on the global think tank stage. He was receptive to engagement with his Chinese peers and remained so even after retiring as Heritage's president in 2013. Several notable high-profile meetings between Feulner and CCG leadership took place in the late 2010s, highlighting his commitment to dialogue.

In the fall of 2017, a CCG delegation traveled to Washington. Our last stop was a visit to the Heritage Foundation's headquarters, where we met with Dr. Feulner.

During this meeting, CCG President Dr. Wang Huiyao and Dr. Feulner held fruitful discussions on US-China relations. Dr. Feulner warmly received the delegation and praised CCG's engagement, stressing that robust exchanges between think tanks can significantly aid decision-making in both governments by reducing misunderstandings. Feulner also briefed the CCG team on Heritage's operations and his involvement in advising the US administration at the time, underscoring a mutual desire to keep dialogue channels open even amid political shifts.

The following year, as trade tensions simmered, Dr. Feulner again personally engaged with visitors from CCG. On September 27, 2018, the Heritage Foundation hosted a private luncheon in Washington for a visiting CCG delegation that was also attended by Asia Studies Director Walter Lohman and research fellow Patrick Tyrrell, among others. Discussions focused on the scope of US-China economic and trade ties at a sensitive time in negotiations.

⁶ This essay was written on July 20, 2025 in remembrance of Dr. Edwin J. Feulner, founder and long-time President of the Heritage Foundation, passed away at age 83 on July 18, 2025. The loss of Dr. Feulner, a colleague and a friend, has left a personal and professional gap that will not soon be filled.

Feulner sitting at the head of the table was a clear sign of Heritage's openness to candid dialogue. Both sides exchanged views on trade policy, investment, and areas where the two countries could still find common ground despite their disputes at the time. The Chinese attendees were particularly impressed by his graciousness and strategic insights.

Even after travel all but ceased during the COVID-19 pandemic, Dr. Feulner continued to maintain regular communication with CCG. On January 12, 2022, CCG and the Heritage Foundation jointly organized an online seminar titled "An Outlook for US-China Relations in 2022." Dr. Wang Huiyao and Dr. Feulner met in a virtual chat room for a discussion moderated in part by Heritage that touched on the trajectory of US-China relations under the Biden administration and prospects for rebuilding trust. Feulner offered historical perspectives from his decades in Washington, assessing challenges and opportunities for the bilateral relationship in 2022. This virtual reunion once again demonstrated Feulner's unwavering belief in engagement.

Former US Ambassador to China Terry Branstad, who had recently joined Heritage as a distinguished fellow, also joined the online discussion, adding insights from his diplomatic experience.

Dr. Feulner's direct interactions with CCG over the years were marked by warmth, respect, and a genuine exchange of ideas. He consistently emphasized the value of open communication between the US and China, even when political winds blew strong in Washington. In each encounter, Feulner acted as a bridge—sharing conservative viewpoints while listening to Chinese perspectives. His legacy in this regard is one of openness and civility: he demonstrated that even a proud leader of a conservative think tank saw merit in engaging across cultures. CCG, in return, viewed Feulner as a true friend in the American intellectual community. His passing is deeply felt, but the dialogues he helped initiate will be remembered as guiding lights for future Sino-American understanding. Beyond Dr. Feulner's personal involvement, CCG and the Heritage Foundation have built a broader relationship of exchange.

By commemorating Feulner, we also recognize how the Heritage Foundation, under his influence, has remained open to engagement with CCG. The following are a few of the important interactions that we've had in recent years.

In April 2019, as US-China trade talks approached a critical juncture, CCG held its Fifth China and Globalization Forum in Beijing, which was attended by Heritage's Ambassador Terry Miller.

On May 23, 2019, Heritage Foundation's Anthony B. Kim, Editor of the Index of Economic Freedom, came to a CCG-organized training session in Beijing.

In July 2023, CCG visited Michael Pillsbury, a prominent Heritage senior fellow and head of its China research program, at his Heritage office.

In October 2023, Pillsbury attended CCG's conference and visited CCG's Beijing headquarters.

Dr. Edwin J. Feulner played a pivotal role in opening doors between CCG and the Heritage Foundation. Under his leadership and afterward, Heritage did not shy away from conversations with Chinese intellectuals—rather, it actively sought them out. Feulner's personal meetings broke the ice at a time when many in Washington were

growing skeptical of engagement. He proved that principled conservatives could still sit down with Chinese counterparts in search of mutual understanding. Each interaction—whether an informal breakfast, a formal forum, or a private luncheon—built incremental trust. These exchanges allowed both American and Chinese experts to explain their thinking, correct misperceptions, and even find unexpected areas of agreement.

CCG, for its part, has always advocated for open dialogue as a means to stabilize Sino-American relations. In Dr. Feulner, CCG found a willing partner who often disagreed but shared the belief that communication is better than silence, even when official relations soured, or ideological divisions widened. As Feulner once noted during an exchange, think tank dialogues can help avoid misjudgments between great powers by ensuring each side's views are heard. This wisdom rings true today more than ever.

I bid a fond farewell to Ed—a scholar, leader, and bridge builder. The many dialogues between CCG and Heritage that he inspired will remain a cornerstone of our institution's collective memory. We will continue to cherish those moments of understanding and build on them—with other US think tanks and interlocutors as well.

In doing so, we keep alive Dr. Feulner's hope that through honest exchange, the United States and China can find a path to peaceful coexistence, even in challenging times. This, perhaps, is one of the most meaningful tributes we can offer to his legacy.

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